

the 1990s, the number of people in the UK who are obese has increased by 50% (Health Survey for England 1995, 1997, 1999, 2001, 2003). The prevalence of obesity in the UK is now 10.5% (Health Survey for England 2003), compared with 6.5% in 1995 (Health Survey for England 1995).

Obesity is a risk factor for a number of chronic diseases, including coronary heart disease, stroke, type 2 diabetes, osteoarthritis, and certain types of cancer (World Health Organization 2000). Obesity is also associated with a number of other health problems, including depression, asthma, and sleep apnoea (World Health Organization 2000). The health problems associated with obesity are a major cause of morbidity and mortality in the UK, and are a major cause of health care costs.

Obesity is a complex condition, and its aetiology is multifactorial. It is caused by a combination of genetic, environmental, and behavioural factors. Genetic factors play a role in the development of obesity, but environmental and behavioural factors are also important. Environmental factors include diet and physical activity, while behavioural factors include eating and drinking habits.

Obesity is a preventable condition, and there are a number of ways in which it can be prevented. These include eating a healthy diet, being physically active, and avoiding smoking and drinking alcohol. Obesity can also be treated, and there are a number of ways in which it can be treated. These include diet and physical activity, and in some cases, surgery.

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